making improvements to some of the major roads and highways and one in particular, the Agra-Ajmer road, was described by Badauni:

> A lofty college and high and spacious palaces were built on the road to Ajmer…. …he ordered a palace to be built at every stage…and a pillar to be erected and a well sunk at every kos. Ever so many hundreds of thousands of stags' horns, which the Emperor had killed during the course of his life, were placed on these pillars as a memorial to the world.

While the Jesuits were making their weary journey from Goa, sixty-seven Jain monks from Gujarat, silent and barefoot, were preparing to leave for the Mughal court too. Elsewhere, Brahmins were gathering their few possessions as were Sufi monks, and aberrant, long-haired yogis, all preparing to head to Fatehpur Sikri because Akbar wanted to meet with the seekers of the sublime, the speakers of seductive truths. 'For a long time, it was the custom that the dull and superficial regarded the heartfelt words of holy souls as foolishness,' agreed Abu'l Fazl. 'They recognized wisdom nowhere but in the schools and did not know that acquired knowledge is for the most part stained with doubts and suspicions. Insight is that which without schooling illuminates the pure temple of the heart.'

This spirit of joyous enquiry was rare for the times. In England, a small nation of some four million people, Queen Elizabeth I had recently been excommunicated by the Pope after she had wrested the throne from her sister, Mary Tudor, who had been wont to burn 'heretics' at the stake, and came to be known as Bloody Mary. Under Elizabeth I, Catholics and Jesuits were those who were persecuted and Muslims, if they were acknowledged at all, were always 'Saracens', the crusading Arabs. In France, the Protestant Huguenots were waging war on the Catholics and had desecrated statues in the Gothic cathedral of Notre Dame in Paris. This was also Spain's century of conquest. In vast tracts of the Caribbean and South America they introduced a plundering mix of religion, disease, rapacity, and destruction. Meanwhile the three great empires that covered the Dar al-Islam—the Ottomans, the Safavids and the Mughals—were crucibles of cultural creativity and cosmopolitan movement. Scholar Jerry Brotton, writing of an English soldier's first visit to Morocco at this time observed that coming from 'the monoglot world of England and Ireland and its stark religious divisions between Protestant and Catholic, the multi-confessional